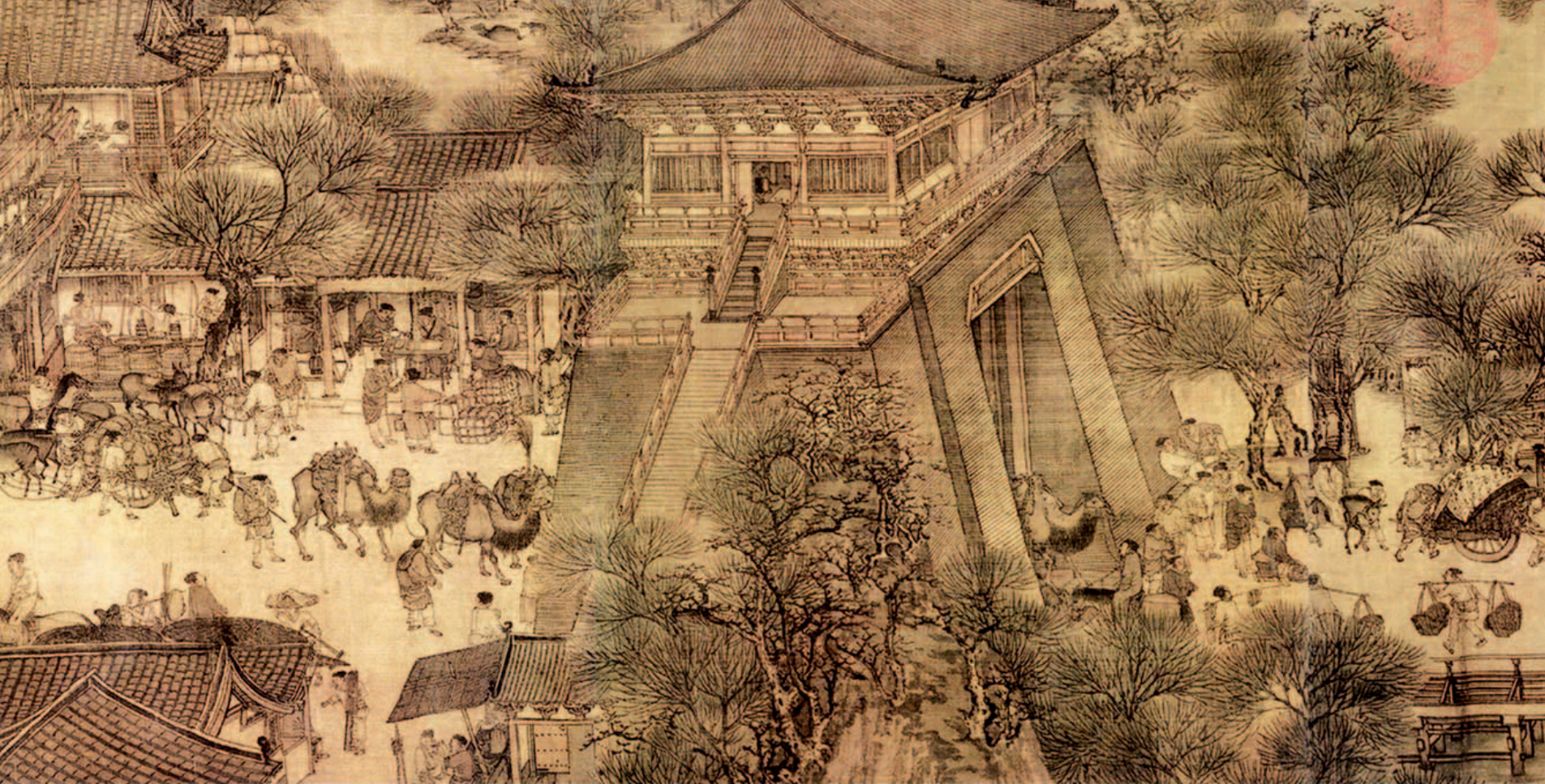




The Zhang Zeduan silk scroll

The Spring Festival Along the River, by the Northern Song artist Zhang Zeduan, depicts bustling scenes of city life in Kaifeng, the Northern Song capital. Note the upward curve of the roofs, typical of the period.

examinations. The system attempted to ensure that talent, not birth or wealth, enabled a candidate to pass. More than 60 percent of successful candidates for the *jìnshì* degree came from families that had not gained an appointment for an official in the bureaucracy for three generations. However, poor families were still unlikely to foster a successful candidate, as applicants needed to be wealthy or literate to enable them to prepare for the examinations.

From early in the Song period, scholars and officials were constantly proposing ideas for reforms to rectify the problems of the day. In 1068, Emperor Shenzong entrusted Wang Anshi, China's most famous reformer, with tackling the nation's problems. He identified the main cause of the state's weakness to be a shortage of funds, and raised money by imposing a government monopoly on tea, challenging wealthy families who were evading taxes, and offering interest-free loans to peasants

burdened with debt. To reduce the cost of the standing army, he required every household to supply men for a local militia. These reforms caused an outcry. Wang Anshi was dismissed, and the controversy that his acts had aroused permanently weakened the dynasty.

The Southern Song

The dynasty also had to deal with the challenge of non-Chinese regimes to the north. Part of northern China was already ruled by the Qidan Liao dynasty. In 1115 the Jurchen, a seminomadic people from Manchuria, established the Jin dynasty. In 1125 they overran the Qidan Liao, and two years later they captured Kaifeng. The Song court was forced to flee south, bringing an end to the retrospectively named Northern Song. The Southern Song emperors went on to fix their capital at Hangzhou. Although militarily weak, the Southern Song was also a period of continuing economic growth and social change.

Under the Southern Song, new philosophical ideas developed. Neo-Confucianists borrowed concepts from Daoism and Buddhism, and their ideas were synthesized by the scholar Zhu Xi. He emphasized the Dao, or "the Way," a philosophical path that individuals could follow through self-cultivation and the study of Confucian classics (see pp.131).

Neo-Confucian values were partly responsible for a deterioration in the rights of women during the Southern Song period. The remarriage of widows was discouraged, and women's property rights were curtailed. Footbinding—the practice of permanently disfiguring a young girl's feet to produce a supposedly attractive shape in later life—became well established during the Song period.

Song porcelain

The Song period is often regarded as the high point in ceramic production in China. Chinese porcelain was first manufactured in the 7th century, a thousand years before the secret of its production was discovered in Europe. True porcelain is made from kaolin, or China clay, the name deriving from Gaoling in Jingdezhen. Song porcelain was the most refined ever produced, and was characterized by the simple elegance of its shape, and its purity of color. The most famous Northern Song wares were created near Dingzhou in northeast China. After the fall of the Northern Song, manufacture was transferred to Hangzhou. In the south, Jingdezhen in Jiangxi was designated a center for the manufacture of imperial porcelain in 1004. It has continued as a major porcelain center to this day.

AFTER

The Mongols took control of China from the Song, ruling as the Yuan dynasty (1279–1368).

THE MONGOLS TAKE CONTROL

The Mongols **destroyed the Jurchen Jin dynasty** in 1234, gaining control of north China. After more than 50 years of attacks by the Mongols, the Song fell in 1279 to **Kublai Khan**, the grandson of Genghis Khan **164–65 »**.



KUBLAI KHAN

MONGOL LAW

Kublai Khan **divided the population** into four classes: on top were the Mongols, then came peoples from Central Asia, then came the northern Chinese—who had been subjugated first by the Mongols—and lastly came the newly conquered Chinese of the Southern Song.

THE SILK ROAD

After the Mongol conquests, it was again safe for **merchants and missionaries** to use the Silk Road **184–85 »**. The first European to record his journey was the Franciscan monk **John of Plano Carpini**, who reached Mongolia in 1246.

INVENTION

GUNPOWDER

A 9th-century Daoist text warned that mixing charcoal, saltpeter, and sulfur formed a dangerous combination; some who had done so had caused explosions and burned down buildings. By 919 CE gunpowder was being used in a flame-thrower, and by the end of the 10th century, simple bombs and grenades had begun to appear. In 1044, the formula for gunpowder was first published, 200 years before it appeared in Europe.

